

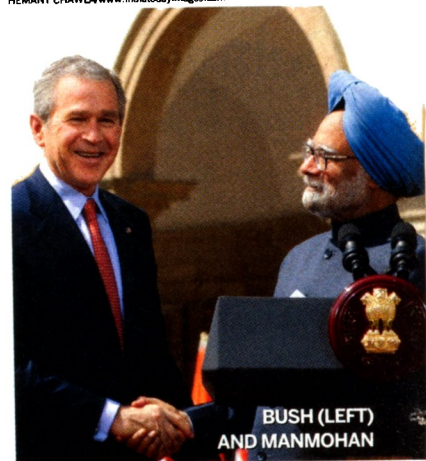
|2006| TAMASHA TV Something to Talk About

It began with a boy in a well. Now, anything that can pass for news will.

PPrince? The boy who fell into a well? In Haldehri village, over there," is the laconic response of a villager as he directs you to one of Kurukshetra district's most famous resident. Over three years ago, a five-year-old boy fell into a 60-ft deep discarded borewell in this Haryana village. This incident mirrored the explosive growth of a great Indian media phenomenon, the news channels. Backed by a booming 9 per cent economy and the crash in the costs of launching a news channel—from Rs 40 crore to Rs 3 crore in less than a decade—their number grew from two channels in 2000 to 38 in 2006 and 73 channels today in a total basket of 417 satellite channels. For a medium hungry for anything that could pass as news, the feeding frenzy was in Haldehri village on July 21. The satellite trucks rumbled in and the boy's 52-hour ordeal was now on national tv. People united in prayer for his well-being even as a team of Indian army engineers dug a shaft to rescue him. The incident turned out to be a windfall of sorts for his father Ram Chander, a landless labourer who spent Rs 5 lakh he got from various benefactors on converting his temporary dwelling into a concrete four-room structure. He now owns a motorbike and carries a cellphone; the milk from two buffaloes earns him Rs 200 each day and he grows wheat on his half-acre field. His son now goes to DAV Public School and wants to join the Indian Army. Prince got channels better ratings than even the Mumbai train bombings of July 11, 2006 in which over 200 people were killed. This was how things were shaping up; common folk starring in reality shows passing off as news—sea water miraculously turning potable, people claiming to be reincarnated snakes and astrologers predicting their exact moment of death. Today, news channels form the largest chunk of all genres and are growing fast, even as Hindi and English channels have registered a dip. TAM Media Research says every incident like a terror strike has propelled viewership and the threshold of news consumption. The genre has not found another Prince—most children who fell into borewells since have died. But the medium has bestowed its child star with Peter Pan-esque immortality. Long after the channels he starred in fade away and hopefully when he realises his dreams, he will always be known as the boy who fell into a well. **by Sandeep Unnithan**

PRINCE, NOW AN EIGHT-YEAR-OLD, IN HALDEHRI

HEMANT CHAWLA/www.indiatodayimages.com



BUSH (LEFT) AND MANMOHAN

THE MAIN EVENT

Indo-US Nuclear Deal

Right from the moment he stepped off Air Force One at Delhi airport, US President George Bush made it clear that he wanted his maiden visit to be a resounding success. With even Prime Minister Manmohan Singh breaking protocol to personally receive him and First Lady Laura Bush, they knew that the sealing of the deal signalled a giant leap in Indo-US relations. For the US President, there are still several hurdles to be crossed, including persuading the US Congress to make suitable amendments in the law in order to lift sanctions against India. Manmohan, too, will have to convince his sceptical allies that the nuclear deal was in the best interest of the nation. If all goes well, that would be the true benefit of the brave new Indo-US relationship.

India Today, March 13, 2006

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FROM TWO NEWS CHANNELS IN 2000, THE NUMBER HAS GONE UP TO 73 TODAY.